

ADULT INTERACTIVE LEARNING

QUESTION FOR DISCUSSION:

The Torah is our guidebook for life studied by scholars for the past 3300 years. The breadth and depth of Jewish scholarship has spawned thousands of brilliant published works, deciphering and applying every word and nuance of Jewish law and teaching. Jews are not meant to just memorize and repeat words of Torah robotically but rather to plumb its depths and intellectually grasp its wisdom.

Yet on the day on which we celebrate the completion of the annual cycle of the Torah, Simchat Torah, we celebrate by dancing and rejoicing rather than by studying. Doesn't that seem incongruous with the purpose and focus of the Torah? Wouldn't it be more appropriate to mark this day by studying the Torah and its timeless wisdom?

Discuss and share your thoughts with your spouse, a friend or yourself.

Here are some thoughts for you to consider:

1. If you had two employees to hire and one of them had great enthusiasm and joy for your company and its mission, would you see that as an advantage? In what way does our celebration demonstrate our acceptance and commitment to Torah, more than study?

Beyond an intellectual pursuit the Torah is a marriage. We stick together through the vicissitudes of life and we never let go. At a wedding you dance and celebrate, not just discuss the nuances of married life.

Dancing unites us; study categorizes us into different levels of intellectual ability. Every one of us have a connection with the Torah because it is our inheritance and even a one day old child inherits equally with a grown learned scholar. Anyone can dance, but not everyone has the intellectual ability to study a deep page of the Talmudic tractate of Yevamos or Uktzin. **On Simchat Torah, we celebrate our unity by dancing, because no one owns the Torah more than you do.**

SO LET'S DANCE AND CELEBRATE OUR ETERNAL TREASURE - THE TORAH!



2. There is an additional fundamental reason for dancing on Simchat Torah.

The study of Torah is all about its fulfillment. Judaism is a religion that focuses most strongly on action far more than study. Dancing with one's feet demonstrates that.

Read and discuss the following quotes that underscore the idea that study of Torah is all about its performance- its purpose is not just an intellectual exercise:

There is no Mitzvah that is equal to Torah study. Rather, Torah study is equal to all the Mitzvot. This is because study leads to Mitzvah performance. (Maimonides, Mishneh Torah 3:5)

- He used to say: “Whenever a person’s [good] deeds exceed his wisdom, his wisdom will endure; but when a person’s wisdom exceeds his [good] deeds, his wisdom will not endure.” (Pirkei Avot, Chapter 2)
- Ramban (Nachmanides) writes in his famous letter to his son that at the end of every study session he should examine what he has learned and see if there is something he can put into practice.
- A school should endeavor to both impart wisdom to its students, and train them in the performance of good deeds. Of the two, however, the primary focus should be good deeds. Indeed, it is through such deeds that knowledge will thrive. (Lubavitcher Rebbe)
- Deed is primary: The primacy of deed can be seen in the fact that we don the arm Tefillin=corresponding to our deeds-before donning the head Tefillin, which corresponds to our wisdom. The head Tefillin is removed prior to the arm Tefillin since the “deed Tefillin” should be upon the person longer than the ‘wisdom Tefillin’. (Yalkut Yehudah)

YOUR POSITIVE ACTION IS THE BEST WAY TO CELEBRATE THE TORAH. WHAT IS ONE MITZVAH YOU WILL TAKE ON THIS SIMCHAT TORAH?

